

Confidence vs complacency

A ball hasn't been bowled in the tournament yet, but it already feels like a lost opportunity for the Indian think tank. When backed into a corner, as it finds itself now after an underwhelming second consecutive group-stage exit in the Women's T20 World Cup, India always likes to show muscle. This situation feels a lot like setting up a decorated M.C. Mary Kom against an amateur boxer a few months into her training. The leadership group — selectors and the coach — had the chance to carry India into a new era in the shortest format by setting a transition into motion from the top down. Harmanpreet Kaur has been captain in the format for a decade, and it's safe to say that she's in the twilight of her career. Allowing a new captain to stamp her authority in the side with Harmanpreet there to oversee the handover isn't the brave task it now seems to be, but that's where we are.

Most of the chosen squad for this edition travelled to England for the T20 showpiece, with only Yastika Bhatia, Shreyanka Patil (fitness) and Jemimah Rodrigues (injury) missing. Yastika's omission has an unfortunate silence attached to it. No explanations have been given about why she is the solitary exclusion from that World Cup squad, despite not being the most troublesome player on the selection chessboard. One can only hope that the lack of clarity for the outsider is balanced by actual conversations with the player, which the Board can be discreet about.

The side has chosen to offer Pratika Rawal (**right**) her maiden T20I call-up in place of Jemimah, a multi-dimensionally puzzling call given her last competitive game in the format was in 2024 and the long

list of players who have been climbing the steep rock of A-level cricket hoping to get into the senior side, only to be pushed back to the start once close to peak. Nikki Prasad, Anushka Sharma and Vrinda Dinesh — who have all registered commendable performances at the domestic level and A series — are some of the notable mentions here.

Bharti Fulmali has been given a longer rope. One hopes her blink-and-miss appearances in the summer are traded for a solid stint in

Did you know?



The inaugural Women's Asia Cup, held in 2004, featured only India and Sri Lanka. The next three editions were also played in the ODI format, before it switched to T20s in 2012.

Harmanpreet Kaur, with 481 runs, is India's highest run-scorer in the tournament's history. Deepti Sharma, with 26 scalps, is India's highest wicket-taker.

India's 201/5 against UAE in the 2024 edition is the highest team score in the tournament's history.

the side. G. Kamalini comes in as Richa Ghosh's reinforcement, a good show of confidence in the abilities of a maverick batter at the U19 level.

The bowling arsenal, too, features the blunted arrows of the T20 World Cup campaign, with Prema Rawat named in the first squad, a step up from the hasty injury replacement role she occupied over the summer. No explanations have been given for why Vaishnavi Sharma hasn't found a place, or why Pooja Vastrakar and Asha Sobhana — who are back playing at the domestic level — are missing. There are also no updates on the fitness of pace-bowling all-rounders Kashvee Gautam and Amanjot Kaur. And those are just a few names from a pool of castaways that is bigger than it should be.

All this notwithstanding, India, with all its imperfections, will settle for nothing less than the title, and it has the mind and the muscle to go all the way without really breaking a sweat. Harmanpreet and Co. know that complacency in their superiority can cost them, as it did in 2024 at Dambulla. Given how the highs of the recent ODI World Cup triumph have come crashing down at this year's T20 World Cup, India — Asian cricket's apex predator — will keep its fingers crossed for a successful hunt.

